

Reading a SERP

Position one is a location, not an outcome. Some SERPs have no clicks left in them at all.

Bottom line

Section 4 read the SERP to decide what kind of page to build. This section reads it to decide whether to build anything. About 60% of Google searches now end with no click, and the features stacked above the organic results decide how much of the remaining traffic ever reaches you. Checking the click economy before you commit is the highest-return ten minutes in SEO.

What sits above you

On a 2026 SERP, "ranking first" means first in the organic list, which can be a long way down the page. Above it you may find, roughly in order of appearance:

- **Ads**, up to four before organic
- **AI Overview**, an AI-generated answer with a handful of cited links
- **Featured snippet**, an extracted answer from one page
- **Knowledge panel**, entity facts pulled from Google's Knowledge Graph
- **Map pack**, three local businesses
- **Shopping pack**, product listings
- **People Also Ask**, expandable related questions
- **Video carousel**, usually YouTube
- **Top stories**, for news-adjacent queries
- **Sitelinks**, expanding one result to occupy far more space

Every one of these pushes organic down and takes a share of attention. On a heavily featured SERP, the first organic result can sit below the fold.

The numbers

Metric	Value	Tier
Searches ending with no click	~60%	[practitioner]
AI Overviews present in results, Q1 2026	~47%	[practitioner]

Metric	Value	Tier
Average CTR, organic position 1	27.6% (Backlinko)	[practitioner]
CTR drop when an AI Overview is present	up to 58%	[practitioner]
CTR, roughly, position 8	~1%	[practitioner]
CTR, roughly, position 4	~5%	[practitioner]

Two conclusions follow, and they point in opposite directions, which is why both matter.

First: ranking first is worth much less than it used to be. A 27.6% CTR on a query where an AI Overview already answered the question is a fraction of that. Position one on a zero-click SERP is a vanity metric.

Second: mid-page movement is worth much more than people think. Going from position 8 to position 4 takes CTR from roughly 1% to roughly 5%. That is about **400% more clicks from the same page, the same content, and the same impressions**. There is usually far more available traffic in improving pages ranked 5 to 15 than in chasing new ones. Section 41 turns this into a repeatable report.

What each feature does to you

AI Overview. The big one. Its presence signals the query is answerable without a click. Being cited inside it is worth having and is a different discipline (Tier 4), but expect the click volume on that query to be structurally lower forever. Roughly half of all SERPs now have one.

Featured snippet. Cuts both ways. You get position zero and prominence, but if the snippet fully answers the question, many searchers stop there. Snippets work well when the answer is a *hook* into something deeper and badly when the answer is the whole product.

People Also Ask. Less a threat than a gift. Every PAA entry is Google telling you a question real searchers ask next about this topic, for free. It is the best keyword research tool nobody pays for, and you will mine it in Section 6.

Map pack. If present, local intent is dominant and the traffic goes to Business Profiles, not web pages. A blog post cannot win here. Route to Section 35.

Shopping pack. Commercial and product-led. Informational content will not capture it.

Video carousel. Google is telling you the preferred format is video. You can compete with text, but you are competing against the format Google chose to feature.

Knowledge panel. Entity-level. If a competitor has one and you do not, that is an entity problem, which is Section 40.

The click-availability test

Before targeting any query, run this. It takes about a minute per query.

- 1 **Search it in incognito.** Scroll to the first organic result. How far down is it?
- 2 **Is there an AI Overview?** If yes, assume the click volume is materially reduced.
- 3 **Does the AI Overview or featured snippet fully answer the question?** If a searcher's need is met on the page, there is little click left regardless of your ranking.
- 4 **Count the features above organic.** Three or more means organic is a minority of the page.
- 5 ****Ask what a click would be for.**** If the answer is a fact, Google has already given it away. If the answer requires a tool, a comparison, a download, a quote, or a decision, the click survives.

The rule of thumb: queries whose answer is a *fact* are being absorbed. Queries whose answer is a *decision* or an *action* still send traffic. Steer your targeting toward decisions and actions.

That is also why commercial investigation is such a strong intent to hold. "Best CRM for a five-person agency" cannot be resolved by a two-sentence answer box. The searcher has to weigh things, and weighing requires reading.

Impressions versus clicks: the diagnostic

This is the single most useful pattern in Search Console, and it will come back in Section 41 and every traffic-drop diagnosis you ever run.

- **Impressions down, clicks down.** You lost rankings or visibility. A ranking problem.
- **Impressions flat or up, clicks down.** You still rank. Something above you is taking the click, usually an AI Overview or a new SERP feature. Not a ranking problem, and ranking work will not fix it.
- **Impressions up sharply, CTR collapsed.** You are ranking for a lot of new queries badly, often broad ones you do not deserve.

Most people never separate these and treat every decline as a ranking failure. It usually is not.

What still gets clicked

Not everything is being absorbed. Consistently click-worthy:

- **Comparisons and alternatives.** Require judgement across options.
- **Tools and calculators.** The value is the interaction, which cannot be summarized.
- **Original data and research.** The AI Overview will often cite you and send the curious.
- **Pricing and specifics.** Frequently absent from AI answers and commercially valuable.
- **Anything requiring trust.** People want to see who they would be hiring.

Look at that list. It is nearly identical to the list of things that also earn links and AI citations. That convergence is not a coincidence, and it is the strategic thread running through the whole course.

Why this matters

most people pick targets by search volume and difficulty and never ask whether the SERP has clicks in it. That is how you rank first for something and get nothing. Reading the click economy first is what separates targeting from wishful thinking.

Do this now

- 1 **Pick three queries** from your Section 4 sheet: one informational, one commercial investigation, one transactional.
- 2 **Screenshot each full SERP** in incognito, from the top of the page down to the first organic result.
- 3 **Annotate each screenshot.** Mark every feature above organic, how far down organic starts, and whether an AI Overview is present.
- 4 **Run the click-availability test on all three** and score each: healthy click volume, reduced, or effectively zero.
- 5 **Add two columns to your Section 4 sheet:** "AI Overview present" and "click availability". Fill them for all 20 queries.
- 6 **Open Search Console, Performance, last 6 months, and enable both Impressions and Clicks.** Look for any query where impressions held and clicks fell. Note it. That is a CTR problem, not a ranking problem, and you now know the difference.

Capstone step

Your intent sheet now carries a click-availability verdict for all 20 target queries. You know which of your targets are worth pursuing for traffic, which are worth pursuing only for AI citation and brand presence, and which are not worth pursuing at all. That distinction drives every prioritization decision from Section 8 onward.

Key takeaways

- Position one is a location on the page, not an outcome. About 60% of searches end with no click, and roughly half of SERPs now carry an AI Overview.
- The biggest untapped traffic is usually mid-page. Moving position 8 to position 4 is roughly 400% more clicks from content you already have.
- Queries answered by a fact are being absorbed. Queries answered by a decision, a tool, or an action still send traffic. Target the second kind.
- Impressions flat with clicks falling is a CTR problem, not a ranking problem. Ranking work will not fix it, and confusing the two wastes months.

